preserving the human body in health'. Marco also makes cursory remarks about Camorin and Kannur.

Of the flora and fauna on the Malabar Coast, Marco says, 'Everything there is different from what it is with us and excels both in size and beauty . . . lions, leopards, and lynxes abound, as do peacocks and scarlet and blue parrots of which there is no lovelier sight in the world.' Some monkeys in the region have 'such distinctive appearance that you might take them for men'.

He notes pepper and indigo plantations, incense, a date wine that is 'a very good drink'. Further north in Gujarat, workshops make cotton and leather goods, shiploads of which go west every year. With such precious cargo plying the sea, piracy too operates on a large scale. In Aden, the cargo is transferred to smaller ships and carried via rivers and camels to the Nile and downriver to Alexandria and beyond. These goods include cushions and 'handsome mats of scarlet leather, embossed with birds and beasts and stitched with gold and silver . . . of more consummate workmanship than anywhere in the world . . . so exquisite that they are a marvel to behold'. Marco visits Cambay and the 'kingdom of Somnath', where people 'live by trade and industry, as honest folk ought to do'. This more or less ends Marco's travels in India spanning multiple months.

Other travellers in the next two centuries would help create a richer portrait of the Malabar Coast. These include a diverse lot: Ibn Battuta of Morocco, Ma Huan of China, Abdur Razzaq of Persia, Niccolò de' Conti of Italy and Afanasy Nikitin of Russia. In 'the Malabar lands,' Ibn Battuta writes in the 1340s, there are twelve infidel kings (i.e., not Muslim, Christian or Jew), 'some of them strong with armies numbering fifty thousand men, and others weak with armies of three thousand. Yet there is no discord [whatsoever] between them, and the strong does not desire to seize the possessions of the weak'.[4] Battuta notes that the entire road from Goa to Kollam,

> runs beneath the shade of trees, and at every half mile there is a wooden shed with benches on which all travellers, whether Muslims or infidels, may sit. At each shed there is a well for drinking and an infidel who is incharge of it. If the traveller is an infidel he gives him water in vessels; if he is a Muslim, he pours the water into his hands . . . It is the custom of the infidels in the Malabar lands that no Muslim may enter their houses or eat from their vessels; if he does so they break the vessels or give them to the Muslims. [Fortunately,] on this road there are houses belonging to Muslims, at which Muslim